The Second Lebanon War, 2006

The Second Lebanon War has become ingrained in the consciousness of the Israeli public as a failure. The public's and the media's preoccupation with it became, I believe, second only to the Yom Kippur War. As a citizen of this country and as someone who still knew a thing or two about what was going on in Israel's security apparatus during the time of the war, I expressed my objections to the war's critics in closed circles. Today (in 2018), with the passage of time, it is worth trying to remove the mark of disgrace that Israel affixed upon itself after this war, with the generous help of the Israeli media and irresponsible politicians.

I will begin with the facts, about which there is no dispute. On July 12, 2006, a Hezbollah force commanded by Imad Mughniyeh and with the approval and blessing of Hezbollah leader Sheikh Hassan Nasrallah laid an ambush on IDF patrols along the Israeli-Lebanese border and attacked without any provocation, kidnapping two soldiers and killing eight others. The purpose of the operation was to capture Israeli soldiers in order to negotiate a prisoner exchange. It soon became apparent that the two soldiers had been seriously injured during the operation and had died immediately afterwards. The Second Lebanon War was a direct result of this event.

What were the main characteristics of this war? First, it was a war that was forced upon us and, from our point of view, a just war that, to the best of my judgment, met the conditions of the definition of a "war of no choice." My definition of the war as one of no choice will almost certainly provoke opposition and even hostility. Well, according to my interpretation, the definition of "no choice" is more complex and multifaceted than simply that a war is justified only when the alternative is the country's annihilation. When we withdrew from Lebanon in 2001, we warned Hezbollah that for every provocation on its part we would respond with a massive blow. Hezbollah systematically tested, with violent actions against us, the limits of what we were willing to withstand. We did not stand behind the threat we issued in 2001 and did not respond, so they continued to raise the bar with each new provocation. The provocation of July 12, 2006, immediately took eight soldiers from us, as well as two other soldiers who, from the outset, were estimated not to be alive (though for various reasons this was not officially confirmed) and who were kidnapped as bargaining chips for